

Chapter Sixteen

Safe Enough

The word safe followed Nora all morning.

It followed her into the shower, where she stood beneath water that was too hot and tried not to imagine Maya asking the question.

Is Nora safe?

It followed her into the kitchen, where Adam made coffee in silence because neither of them knew what kind of morning came after honesty had nearly split the room open.

It followed her to the window, where the city moved beneath a pale sky, indifferent and full of people who probably believed safety was a simple thing.

Safe meant doors locked.

Safe meant no one shouting behind a wall.

Safe meant a body that stayed where it belonged.

But Maya had not meant that.

Maya had meant: Can I give Nora my pain without becoming responsible for what it does to her?

Adam had meant: Can I tell Nora the truth without losing her to fear?

And Nora, though she hated herself for it, had to ask the worst version of the question too.

Could she be trusted with the people she loved?

Adam set a mug beside her.

“Coffee,” he said.

“Thank you.”

He did not ask if she was okay.

She appreciated that.

Then she hated that she appreciated it because it meant even care now required strategy.

Adam leaned against the counter, both hands around his own mug. His hair was still damp from the shower. He looked younger in the morning light. More tired too.

“I should have told you differently,” he said.

Nora turned from the window. “About Maya?”

“Yes.”

“You told me honestly.”

“I told you abruptly.”

“You were scared I’d find out another way.”

“Yes.”

She nodded.

That truth sat between them without accusation.

“I’m glad you told me,” she said.

Adam studied her face, as if checking whether the sentence had hidden edges.

It did not.

Mostly.

Nora took a breath. “It hurt.”

“I know.”

“But I’m glad.”

Adam looked down into his coffee.

“I don’t want to be someone people have to discuss in careful rooms,” she said.

His jaw tightened. “You’re not a problem to be discussed.”

“But I am a situation.”

He did not answer.

Nora smiled faintly, without humor. “See? Honest silence.”

Adam looked up. “You are a person going through something none of us understand. And yes, sometimes we need to talk about how to handle that without hurting you or ourselves.”

The sentence was reasonable.

That made it difficult to resent.

Nora wrapped both hands around her mug.

“Do you think I’m safe?” she asked.

Adam’s face changed.

There were questions that did not ask for information. They asked someone to choose where to place the knife.

He did not answer quickly.

Nora almost told him not to answer at all.

Then he said, “I think you are trying to become safe enough.”

Safe enough.

Not a perfect answer.

Maybe the only honest one.

Nora looked back out the window.

Down on the street, a woman was trying to open an umbrella with one hand while holding a child’s backpack in the other. The child kept jumping into puddles. The woman looked irritated, then laughed despite herself.

Weather behind skin.

Nora felt it faintly now, almost always. Not enough to pull her. Not enough to become a jump. But enough to know the world was never quiet.

“Safe enough,” she repeated.

Adam came to stand beside her.

“For now,” he said, “that might be the goal.”

After breakfast, Adam left for work.

He kissed her at the door.

Asked first.

She said yes.

The kiss was soft, careful, and sad around the edges.

When he was gone, Nora stood in the apartment and did not know what to do with herself.

There were messages on her phone.

One from Daniel, her brother.

Thanks for Sunday. You kept my secret weirdly well.

Nora laughed despite everything.

She replied:

Trying a new thing called emotional restraint. Mixed reviews so far.

Daniel answered:

Sounds fake but proud of you.

Then another message came.

From Maya.

Can we talk later?

Nora stared at it.

The pressure did not come immediately.

That felt like progress.

She typed:

Yes. Phone or in person?

Maya replied:

In person. Garden?

The old church garden.

Again.

Nora's thumb hovered above the keyboard.

The garden was where Maya had told her the truth about Tomas. Where Nora had jumped into Anna's grief. Where the three of them had written their first rules like children building a fence out of sticks against a flood.

She wrote:

Yes. What time?

Maya:

4.

Then, after a minute:

This is not bad. Just honest.

Nora sat down slowly.

Just honest.

That was becoming the most frightening category of all.

At four o'clock, the garden was colder than before.

The fig tree stood bare, its branches dark against a sky the color of wet paper. The statue of the saint watched from her corner, face blurred by weather, palms open as if she had once been asked for answers and had finally given up pretending she had them.

Nora arrived exactly on time.

Not early.

That felt important.

Maya was already there.

She sat on the bench with her hands tucked into the sleeves of her coat. Her hair was pinned back loosely, and her face carried the exhaustion Nora had begun to recognize as not temporary, but seasonal. The season of hospitals. The season of waiting rooms. The season of trying to speak normally while fear sat beside every sentence.

“Hi,” Maya said.

“Hi.”

Nora sat beside her, leaving a careful space.

Maya noticed it.

“I hate that space,” she said.

Nora looked at her. “I thought it was respectful.”

“It is. I still hate it.”

“Do you want me closer?”

Maya looked down at her hands.

“Yes. But not too close.”

Nora moved an inch.

Maya laughed once, softly. “That was almost literal.”

“I am trying to follow instructions.”

“You are very annoying when obedient.”

Nora smiled.

The smile did not last.

Maya drew a breath.

“Adam told you.”

Nora’s hands tightened in her lap.

“Yes.”

“I asked him to.”

That surprised her.

Nora turned. “You did?”

Maya nodded. “I almost texted you myself. Then I thought I’d either soften it too much or make it sound worse. Adam was there when I asked, so...” She shrugged. “I asked him to tell you.”

Nora looked toward the church wall.

“He did.”

“And you stayed?”

The question was quiet.

Nora swallowed.

“Barely.”

“But you stayed.”

“Yes.”

Maya’s shoulders lowered slightly.

For a while, they listened to the distant traffic beyond the garden wall.

Then Maya said, “I need to tell you why I asked.”

Nora nodded.

Maya's voice was careful. "When you came to the hospital, you were good. I don't mean that like a grade."

"You absolutely do."

"I partly do." Maya smiled faintly. "But you were. You listened. You didn't take over. My father liked you. My mother felt less alone. I felt..." She paused. "I felt like maybe I could trust you with this."

Nora held very still.

"Then later," Maya continued, "I got scared because trusting you felt good."

The words turned strangely inside Nora.

Maya looked at her. "Does that make sense?"

"Yes."

"It felt good, and then I thought, what if I forget to protect myself? What if one good day makes me ignore everything that happened before? What if I invite you closer and then you search me again?"

Nora flinched.

Maya saw it, but went on.

"I know you're trying. I know you didn't choose the jumps. I know all of that. But part of me still feels like I have to stand guard around myself when I'm near you."

Nora's eyes burned.

"I'm sorry."

"I know." Maya's voice softened. "But I need more than sorry."

"What do you need?"

Maya looked at the saint for a long moment.

“I need you to tell me when your fear starts making stories about me.”

Nora frowned slightly. “What?”

“Before it becomes an accusation. Before it becomes a jump, if you can. Before you punish me for a version of myself that only exists in your head.”

The words were gentle.

They still pierced.

Maya turned to her. “Like with Adam. If something hurts, tell me it hurts. But don’t make me prove I’m not betraying you every time I receive comfort from someone else.”

Nora looked down.

There it was.

The center of it.

The betrayal that had not happened, still leaving bruises.

“I can try,” Nora said.

Maya nodded.

“No swearing. Just trying.”

Nora gave a weak laugh. “You know me too well.”

“I do. That is the problem and the blessing.”

The wind moved through the rosemary bushes, releasing a faint, sharp scent.

Nora pressed her hands together.

“I was jealous,” she said.

The confession came out bluntly.

Maya did not move.

Nora stared at her own fingers. “In the car. When I jumped into you. I know what you felt. I know it wasn’t romantic. I know you wished it was me. I know all of that.” She swallowed. “But I was still jealous.”

Maya looked away.

Not shocked.

Hurt.

Nora forced herself to continue. “Not because you did anything wrong. Because you needed comfort and I had made myself hard to need.”

Maya closed her eyes.

“And Adam was there,” Nora said. “And he was gentle. And I hated that his gentleness belonged to you in that moment. Then I hated myself for hating it.”

The silence after was long enough to become frightening.

Then Maya whispered, “Thank you for saying that instead of turning it into my fault.”

Nora wiped quickly beneath one eye.

“I almost did.”

“I know.”

The honesty between them was not soft. It was raw, unvarnished, sometimes ugly. But it stood.

Maya looked at her again.

“I was jealous too,” she said.

Nora blinked.

“Of what?”

“Of Adam.”

Nora stared at her.

Maya laughed sadly. “Not like that. I was jealous that he could be scared for you in a cleaner way than I could. He could focus on you. I had my father, my mother, the hospital, you, the jumps, my anger at you, my guilt for being angry. Adam got to just love you.”

Nora had never considered that.

Maya continued, “And I hated that he could say hard things to you and still be your safe place afterward. When I say hard things, I feel like I’m risking the whole sisterhood.”

“Maya.”

“It’s true.” Her mouth trembled. “Being your sister feels like the most beautiful thing I ever chose. But sometimes it feels like holding a glass ornament over a stone floor.”

Nora could not speak.

The image entered her and broke open.

Maya took a shaky breath. “I don’t want us to be breakable like that.”

“We are,” Nora said.

Maya looked at her.

Nora’s voice shook. “Maybe we are breakable. But maybe that doesn’t mean we’re weak. Maybe it means we have to stop pretending love is safe just because it’s real.”

Maya’s eyes filled.

“That sounded annoyingly wise.”

“I hate when that happens.”

Maya laughed through tears.

Then she reached across the space between them and took Nora’s hand.

The pressure came immediately.

Small.

Sharp.

Behind Nora's eyes.

Nora stiffened.

Maya felt it through their joined hands.

"Nora?"

Nora's first instinct was to lie.

Fine.

Nothing.

It passed.

But Maya had asked for the truth before the story.

Nora gripped her hand. "Pressure."

Maya went pale but did not let go.

"From me?"

"I don't know."

The garden wavered.

Not enough to vanish.

Enough to threaten.

Maya's hand trembled in hers.

"What do we do?"

Nora breathed hard.

"Talk."

"About what?"

"Anything true."

Maya's eyes widened. "That is broad."

"Tell me something you want me to know. Something you choose."

Maya understood.

Her grip tightened.

"My father is scared," she said quickly. "More than he shows. My mother knows and pretends not to. I am angry every time someone says he is strong because I think they are asking him to perform strength for their comfort."

The pressure paused.

Nora held on.

Maya continued, words spilling now. "I am scared he will die. I am scared he will live and suffer. I am scared I will become cruel from exhaustion. I am scared I will resent people who get ordinary problems."

The garden steadied.

Nora's breath shook.

"Keep going," she whispered.

Maya was crying now.

"I am scared that if I need you too much, I will lose the version of you who feels like home. I am scared that if I need you too little, I will lose you anyway. I am scared of Adam knowing how tired I am because he looks at tired people like he wants to carry them. I am scared of your fear. I am scared of my anger. I am scared that I will wake up one day and not recognize any of us."

The pressure faded.

Not dramatically.

Like a tide going out.

Nora exhaled.

Maya watched her, terrified.

“Still here?” she asked.

Nora nodded.

“Still here.”

Maya began to cry harder.

This time, Nora did not move closer until Maya pulled her in.

Then they held each other on the bench beneath the bare fig tree.

No jump came.

No stolen memory.

No private room forced open.

Only Maya’s chosen truth, offered in shaking hands.

When Maya finally pulled back, her face was blotchy and wet.

“That was horrible,” she said.

Nora laughed weakly. “Very.”

“But it worked?”

“I think so.”

Maya wiped her face with her sleeve. “Great. The cure is emotional honesty. Disgusting.”

Nora smiled.

Then both of them laughed.

Not because anything was funny.

Because they had survived something awful and needed the body to choose another sound.

After a while, Maya leaned back against the bench.

“I want Adam to know some of that,” she said.

“Okay.”

“Not all.”

“Okay.”

“You won’t tell him?”

“No.”

Maya looked at her.

Nora held her gaze. “That is yours.”

Maya nodded.

Trust did not return all at once.

It arrived in small, suspicious pieces.

But it arrived.

Adam came to the garden at dusk because Maya invited him.

That mattered.

He approached through the gate with both hands in his coat pockets, cautious in the way people became when they knew they had entered a fragile room.

Maya looked at Nora before he reached them.

“Remember,” she said.

“Yours,” Nora answered.

Maya nodded.

Adam stopped a few feet away. “Hi.”

Maya patted the bench on her other side. “Sit. We had a breakthrough, and it was deeply unpleasant.”

Adam looked at Nora.

She nodded.

He sat.

Maya told him some of it.

Not everything. Not the parts she had marked private by leaving them unsaid. She told him she was angry when people called her father strong. She told him she was afraid of becoming cruel from exhaustion. She told him she needed help that did not turn into management.

Adam listened.

Really listened.

Not fixing.

Nora watched him fight the urge.

Maya noticed too.

“Your face is doing the thing,” she said.

Adam blinked. “What thing?”

“The thing where you silently build a spreadsheet of solutions.”

“I do not have a spreadsheet.”

Nora gave him a look.

He sighed. “It is more of a mental checklist.”

Maya pointed at him. “No checklist.”

Adam nodded. “No checklist.”

The three of them sat together as the sky darkened.

There was awkwardness.

There was tenderness.

There was the strange, bruised relief of people learning to speak before fear translated for them.

Then Adam said, “I should say something too.”

Nora turned.

Maya watched him.

Adam looked down at his hands. “I am afraid of being needed only when I’m useful.”

The sentence changed the air.

Nora stilled.

Maya did too.

Adam did not look at either of them.

“I know neither of you means to do that,” he said. “But I don’t always know who I am in this if I’m not fixing, driving, calling, calming, explaining, holding the situation together.”

Nora’s chest tightened.

Adam continued, “And sometimes I’m angry. Not at you. Not exactly. Just angry that I’m scared too and there isn’t much room for that.”

Maya whispered, “Adam.”

He smiled faintly, still looking down. “I’m fine.”

Nora almost laughed and cried at once.

Maya pointed at him. “Forbidden phrase.”

He looked up.

Nora’s eyes were wet. “Very forbidden.”

Adam’s smile broke.

For a moment, he looked younger. Not steady. Not careful. Just tired.

Nora reached for his hand.

Stopped.

“Can I?”

He nodded.

She took it.

Maya took his other hand.

The three of them sat like that on the bench: not a triangle of suspicion, but of grief, fear, and chosen loyalty.

For once, Nora did not feel outside the scene.

For once, she did not feel inside anyone either.

She was only one person among three.

The pressure did not come.

Maybe because nothing was hidden.

Not everything had been said.

But enough had been offered.

Enough doors opened from the inside.

When they left the garden, they walked together to the street.

Maya went home first, hugging them both before she left. She held Nora a little longer.

“Safe enough,” she whispered.

Nora pulled back.

“What?”

Maya smiled sadly. “Adam told me.”

Nora looked at him.

He lifted both hands. “It was a useful phrase.”

Nora rolled her eyes, but her throat tightened.

Safe enough.

Not healed.

Not harmless.

Not certain.

Enough to try.

After Maya left, Adam and Nora walked in the opposite direction.

The city lights came on around them.

Nora glanced at him. “Were you really angry?”

Adam smiled faintly. “You say that like I confessed to murder.”

“You rarely admit anger.”

“I rarely know what to do with it.”

“What does it feel like?”

He thought for a moment.

“Like wanting to put something heavy down, but there’s nowhere to place it.”

Nora nodded.

“I know that feeling.”

He looked at her.

“I’m sorry there hasn’t been room,” she said.

Adam took a breath.

Then nodded.

“Thank you.”

They kept walking.

At the corner, he reached for her hand without stopping himself this time.

Nora let him.

No door opened.

No pressure came.

But she felt the world around them, still full of hidden weather.
People passing with their own grief, anger, tenderness, shame.
Rooms Nora had no right to enter. Stories she might never know.

For once, she did not feel cheated by not knowing.

She felt relieved.

Somewhere behind them, the church bells rang the hour.

Nora listened until the final note faded.

Then she walked on, holding Adam's hand, carrying Maya's trust carefully beside her own.

Safe enough.

For now, it was not a verdict.

It was a promise they would have to keep choosing.